

the later *prisci theologi*.²² Although kabbalistic doctrines are generally in agreement with these teachings, Pico notes that it was Orpheus who first independently formulated them. In an account by Piero Crinito we read:

That divine philosophy of Pythagoras, which they called Magic, belonged to a great extent to the Mosaic tradition; since Pythagoras had managed to reach the Jews and their doctrines in Egypt, and knowledge of many of their sacred mysteries. For even the learning of Plato (as is established) comes quite near to Hebrew truth; hence many called him a genuine Moses, but speaking Greek. Zoroaster, the son of Oromasius, in practicing magic, took that to be the cult of God and study of divinity; while engaged in this in Persia he most successfully investigated every virtue and power of nature, in order to know those sacred and sublime secrets of the divine intellect; which subject many people called Theurgy, others Cabala or magic [*ut sacra illa et sublimia divini intellectus arcana cognosceret: quam partum vel theurgiam multi, vel cabbalam alii, vel magicem etiam dixerunt*].²³

Here, Pythagoras and even Plato are pictured as dependent from the Mosaic theology, while Zoroaster's doctrines agree with kabbalah but were developed independently.

These differences in detail do not change the general impression that the multilinear conception of religious tradition was a major challenge for Christian authors of the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries. That people began to construct genealogies beyond the Christian revelation unmistakably influenced the scientific discourse of later generations. By referring to an imagined tradition of *prisca theologia*, scientific research was emancipated from Christian truth-claims.

Jewish Perspectives

The multilinear conception of religious historiography was an element of differentiation in Islamic discourses of which Suhrawardi is a good example; and it marked an important new development in Christian circles as well. *Claiming tradition* was always, even if implicitly, directed *against* conflicting claims by other religious communities or by other

²² Pico della Mirandola, "De hominis dignitate," in: *Opera omnia*, 330–331; cf. also p. 315.

²³ Crinito, *De Honesta Disciplina Libri XXV*, 81 (quoted from Walker, *Ancient Theology*, 50).

groups within one's own religious heritage. If we apply to this pluralistic situation the analytical instrument of the rational choice theory of religion, it will come with no surprise that pluralistic discourses foster religious commitments. It is the existence of alternatives that promotes the formation of strong identities.²⁴ In the period between the eleventh and the sixteenth centuries, there was no scarcity of alternatives indeed! Therefore, let us now turn to the Jewish construction of 'tradition' and contextualize it in this highly pluralistic situation.

In order to understand the emergence of a new Jewish current that was soon to be known as kabbalah, we have to look at the specific social and religious situation of twelfth-century Spain and southern France.²⁵ Although esoteric interpretations were present in late ancient and medieval Judaism, both within and outside of rabbinic milieus, these took on new characteristics as Jews were confronted with internal and external readings of their own religious heritage. The earliest documentary evidence of systematic kabbalah is found in the *Sefer ha-Bahir* on the one hand—circulated around 1180—and in the writings of Rabbi Isaac the Blind (d. ca. 1235) and his circle, on the other. Scholars agree that the doctrines expressed in these writings were not entirely new; instead, the authors seemed to feel the need of spreading these ideas to a wider public. It is a general characteristic of these and subsequent kabbalistic authors—in particular of the circle that was responsible for the formation of the *Zohar* around 1300—that they belonged to an extremely conservative current in Jewish theological speculation. They saw themselves as guardians of the true Jewish heritage. As noted earlier, the Hebrew term *qabbalah* means "reception," "heritage," or "tradition," i.e. a tradition which was handed down from the beginning of history as a secret knowledge of the Jewish people.²⁶

²⁴ On this thesis, with reference to rational choice theory, see Stark & Finke, *Acts of Faith*; cf. the discussion and further literature in Kippenberg & von Stuckrad, *Einführung in die Religionswissenschaft*, 129–131, and the notion of "plural fields" on p. 132. For methodological reasons, the rational choice theory should be combined with a more nuanced theory of action. A good example of this is Hartmut Esser's concept of *Situationslogik*; see Esser, *Soziologie: Spezielle Grundlagen 1*, particularly pp. 161–169; 295–358.

²⁵ For reasons of convenience, I leave out here the Rhineland Hasidism of the twelfth century. But the picture of a pluralistic situation applies just as well to Ashkenaz, where Judaism was heavily threatened. Furthermore, there definitely were links between the *Hasidei Ashkenaz* and the early kabbalah of the Provence and Spain.

²⁶ There are several other names that were used by kabbalists to describe their teachings. Calling kabbalah the *torat ha-sod* ("secret teaching") or *hokhmat ha-nistar*

Making use of the rabbinic doctrine of oral Torah,²⁷ kabbalists claimed to belong to a superior line of hidden wisdom. The main figure behind the *Zohar*, Moses de Leon (d. 1305), clearly exemplifies this:

This is what is called “kabbalah” [reception], owing to the fact that it is a reception [traceable back] to Moses from Mount Sinai. Moses transmitted it to Joshua, and Joshua transmitted it to the elders, and the elders transmitted it to the prophets, and the prophets transmitted it to the men of the Great Assembly, according to the same process as the reception of the Torah. They transmitted this wisdom one to the next. In fact, this path of wisdom was given to the first man at the moment of his entrance into the garden of Eden. The secret of this wisdom was given to him, and it was with him until he sinned, and was expelled from the garden of Eden. After that, when the first man died, his son Seth inherited this wisdom. After that, this wisdom made its way to Noah the righteous, and he transmitted it to his son Shem, [and this continued] until Abraham our father inherited it, and with this wisdom he worshipped his Creator. He transmitted it to Isaac, and Isaac to Jacob, and Jacob to his sons, [and this continued all the way] to the moment when the later generations stood at Mount Sinai and it was transmitted to Moses our master. From there it was transmitted and received orally, person to person (*‘qibblu ‘ish mi-pi ‘ish’*), through all the subsequent generations. But in the exile this wisdom was forgotten, except for among the very few, and they reawakened this wisdom in each and every generation. For this reason, this wisdom is called “kabbalah” (reception), transmitted orally from person to person. The entire Torah, the written Torah and the oral Torah, is grounded in this wisdom.²⁸

Moses de Leon’s is a strong example of a monolinear construction of tradition. Furthermore, it is not so much the *content* of this heritage that serves as identity marker in kabbalistic discourse but the *reliability of reception*.

For this kabbalist—who may indeed be viewed as paradigmatic—the very definition of Kabbalah is tied to a historical and cultural process. The matters that he sets out to discuss are “Kabbalah” precisely because

(“concealed wisdom”) indicates the esoteric character of kabbalah. Rather than applying the Christian theological category of ‘mysticism’ to these currents, we should talk of ‘esotericism,’ as Elliot R. Wolfson noted (“Occultation of the Feminine” and his introduction to *Rending the Veil*); see also Wolfson, *Abraham Abulafia*, 9–38; Fishbane, “Authority, Tradition, and the Creation of Meaning in Medieval Kabbalah,” 62–63; von Stuckrad, *Western Esotericism*, 35–43.

²⁷ The *locus classicus* for the rabbinic chain of tradition is *Mishnah Avot* 1:1. On the complex meaning of *Torah* see my discussion below in chapter 5.

²⁸ De Leon, *Sefer Sheqel ha-Qodesh*, 17–18.

of the line of *unbroken* historical transmission that he, as a reliable master, is able to posit and assert. His legitimacy and authority to transmit esoteric ideas and practices are entirely dependent on his ability to establish such a firm foundation for reception.²⁹

By focusing on the oral transmission of esoteric doctrine, kabbalists such as Nahmanides or Isaac of Acre (fourteenth century) not only claimed that they followed the ultimate *derekh ha-'emet* ("Way of the Truth")³⁰ but also opened the door to pluralistic understandings of the *content* of tradition. Finding tradition becomes a creative process that allows for the inclusion of quite different interpretations.³¹

Now it may be asked why this rhetoric of tradition was so attractive for kabbalists during that time. Given a framework of tense pluralism in twelfth- and thirteenth-century Provence and Andalusia, Jews formulated their interpretation of tradition as an answer to both internal and external challenges. To begin with the internal conflicts, the philosophical controversies that related to Moses Maimonides (1135–1204) and his (alleged) Aristotelian rationalistic interpretation of Jewish law were of crucial importance. For many Jews, his *Guide of the Perplexed* was the most authoritative work of the time; for others, however, Maimonides seemed to give up any superior, esoteric reading of the Bible, abandoned speculation about the qualities of the godhead as mere anthropomorphism, and made too much use of non-Jewish philosophers, thus watering down the uniqueness of Jewish tradition.³² These kabbalistic critics—among them Nahmanides, Rabbi Jonah Gerondi, Rabbi Ezra ben Solomon, and Rabbi Azriel—tried to

²⁹ Fishbane, "Authority, Tradition, and the Creation of Meaning in Medieval Kabbalah," 67. He concludes that "reliable reception [...] makes for legitimate transmission."

³⁰ See Wolfson, "By Way of Truth."

³¹ Fishbane, "Authority, Tradition, and the Creation of Meaning in Medieval Kabbalah," 72, speaks of a *pluralistic hermeneutic*; see also pp. 73 and 77 with his discussion of Isaac of Acre's *Me'irat 'Einayim* and the conclusion that "we encounter a construction of pluralistic meaning that is even more extreme than the model of harmonization. Here Isaac's implication goes a step further: truth does not adhere to a single predetermined meaning, insofar as two interpretations may both be true and nevertheless be completely contradictory and incompatible." In a comparable way, Moshe Idel describes this change—although related to Abulafia and his circle—as a "shift from conceptual to technical transmission [that] caused an important change in the very nature of the kabbalist's relation to Scripture." Technical transmission "was much freer in its handling of the text" (Idel, "Transmission in Thirteenth-Century Kabbalah," 154; see also Idel, *Absorbing Perfections*, 390–409).

³² See Green, "Introduction," XL–XLII.

combat the implications of Maimonidean rationalism by embracing Neoplatonic concepts that were particularly suitable for sefirotic kabbalah. It was a discourse of identity that encouraged early kabbalists to publish their teachings.

But there were external factors, as well. In the Castile, in Andalusia, and elsewhere, Jews were confronted with Muslim and Christian conflicts that had significant impact on their self-definition, as well as on the way the Jews were imagined from outside. The pluralistic situation created a number of clichés³³ that we can only explain when all parts of this discourse, i.e. the dynamics of Othering among the scriptural religions, are taken into account.³⁴ “In this context, the *Zohar* may be viewed as a grand defense of Judaism, a poetic demonstration of the truth and superiority of Jewish faith.”³⁵ The kabbalistic authors were well acquainted with Muslim and Christian theology and philosophy. With their claim of tradition, they not only tried to establish a self-conscious attitude in a conflicting situation but also incorporated Muslim and Christian doctrines into their own system. Besides a Neoplatonic framework that was central to esoteric discourse in general, concrete teachings that were attractive to the kabbalists included, among others, the trinity (i.e. a unity in diversity) or Mary as a quasi-divine female figure.³⁶ “Much that is to be found in the *Zohar* was intended to serve as a counterweight to the potential attractiveness of Christianity to Jews, perhaps even to the kabbalists themselves.”³⁷

As a result of this Jewish ideology, multilinear constructions of religious historiography, so crucial for the challenging Christian notion of *prisca theologia*, were generally refused by Jewish authors. Even if kabbalists allowed for a pluralistic reading of Scripture—either through a focus on personal experience or the focus on reliable (oral) transmission rather than on content—this plurality took place in a monolinear framework. The notion of an oral tradition of revelation, taken over from rabbinic narratives into kabbalistic concepts, led to the assumption that non-Jewish authorities had learned their wisdom from Jewish

³³ Strickland (*Saracens, Demons, and Jews*) demonstrates that this pejorative imagery and Othering is itself also a visual phenomenon.

³⁴ An example of such an approach is Anidjar, “*Our Place in al-Andalus*.”

³⁵ Green, “Introduction,” LIX.

³⁶ On the relation between Marian theology and the Bahiric concept of the Shekinah see Schäfer, *Mirror of His Beauty*, 169–172. For the interchange between Safed and Florence, see Idel, “Italy in Safed, Safed in Italy.”

³⁷ Green, “Introduction,” LX.

spiritual teachers. This rhetoric was already widely applied in antiquity, as the works of Artapanus, Alexander Polyhistor, Flavius Josephus, and others reveal.³⁸ It is interesting to see that this narrative of 'tradition' was still defended after the Hermetic writings had entered the stage. Now, Hermes could be seen as identical with the biblical Enoch. Yohanan Alemanno, who was a contemporary of Ficino and a companion of Pico in Florence, even used Platonic philosophy to show the superiority of Jewish tradition.³⁹ In his commentary on the *Song of Songs* he differentiated two philosophical schools. The first is

the sect of the ancient ones, from venerable antiquity up to the generation when prophecy disappeared. They and their sons and disciples thirstily drank their [the prophets'] words up to Plato who was in their [the prophets'] days and in their times. The second sect commenced when prophecy ceased and the days of evil came, from the time of Aristotle and later, up to our days.⁴⁰

Idel remarks that here "Platonic lore is described as being the result of the influence of the Hebrew prophets. In fact, valid philosophy is considered to be contemporary with ancient Israelite prophecy and as having ceased together with it."⁴¹

The polemical character of claiming tradition is also well attested in the works of Isaac ben Judah Abarbanel (1437–1508). Financier and courtier to the kings of Portugal, Spain, and Italy, Abarbanel was also a leading Jewish scholar at the turn of the sixteenth century. He was the foremost representative at court at the time of the 1492 expulsion

³⁸ On the motif 'Abraham teaches the gentiles astrology' see von Stuckrad, *Das Ringen um die Astrologie*, 239, 306–307, 351, 360–361, 451–452, 457 (Moses as astrological teacher), 809.

³⁹ On the relationship between Yohanan Alemanno and Pico see Idel, "The Anthropology of Yohanan Alemanno"; *idem*, *Absorbing Perfections*, 487–492; Novak, "Giovanni Pico della Mirandola and Jochanan Alemanno"; Lelli, *Yohanan Alemanno*; *idem*, "Yohanan Alemanno, Pico della Mirandola e la cultura ebraica italiana del XV secolo"; von Stuckrad, "Christian Kabbalah and Anti-Jewish Polemics."

⁴⁰ Oxford, Bodleian Library, MS Or. 1535, fol. 162, quoted from Idel, "Prisca Theologia in Marsilio Ficino and in Some Jewish Treatments," 140. See also the other examples he presents (especially R. Joseph Shelomo Delmedigo and R. Elijah Hayyim ben Benjamin of Genazzano). On the relation between Alemanno and Lodovico Lazzarelli, Hanegraaff notes that the parallels between Alemanno and Lazzarelli are remarkable and that it is possible "that the two may have known each other personally. Oral transmission of knowledge from Jews to Christians was a prominent and new phenomenon characteristic of the Italian Renaissance" (Hanegraaff & Bouthoorn, *Lodovico Lazzarelli*, 59).

⁴¹ Idel, "Prisca Theologia in Marsilio Ficino and in Some Jewish Treatments," 140.

of Jews from Spain, and during his time in Italy he had contact with leading thinkers, both Jewish and Christian. His influence on the intellectual debate of philosophy, astrology, messianism, and kabbalah was decisive.⁴² Part of his oeuvre can be read as a response to proselytizing attempts on the side of the Christians in Spain and Italy. After his arrival in Italy (1492), he quickly got acquainted with the newly translated Hermetic writings and the emerging Christian readings of Jewish kabbalah that usually had a proselytizing subtext. He strongly refuted these attempts at 'rewriting tradition,' and some of his works were written to convince Spanish *conversos* to return to their elderly faith.⁴³ In his *Yeshu'ot meshiho*, Abarbanel engaged the Christological interpretations of rabbinic sayings commonly known from the *adversus Judaeos* literature.⁴⁴ Against what he regarded as Christian misinterpretations, he set his own influential messianic interpretation, which was informed by Islamic-Jewish astrological speculation of the so-called 'great conjunctions' of Jupiter and Saturn.⁴⁵

Abarbanel's link to the Florentine intellectual circles was indirect. Having begun his Italian sojourn in Aragonese Naples, where he was involved at court and had access to the Neapolitan royal library, he soon got into contact with Yohanan Alemanno and the Averroist Aristotelian Elija del Medigo.⁴⁶ Alemanno was the scholar-in-residence of the da Pisa family during the 1480s and early 1490s, which held

⁴² On Abarbanel, see Netanyahu, *Don Isaac Abravanel*; Lawee, *Isaac Abarbanel's Stance toward Tradition*; Borodowski, *Isaac Abravanel on Miracles, Creation, Prophecy, and Evil* (interestingly enough, Borodowski completely neglects astrology); Feldman, *Philosophy in a Time of Crisis*.

⁴³ See Ben-Shalom, "The Converso as Subversive"; Lawee, *Isaac Abarbanel's Stance toward Tradition*, 131.

⁴⁴ On this genre see Schreckenberg, *Die christlichen Adversus-Judaeos-Texte*.

⁴⁵ See the discussion in chapter 6 below.

⁴⁶ As Alemanno, del Medigo (1463–1498), too, had personal contact with Pico della Mirandola. He was introduced to Abarbanel by Saul Hakohen as a "wise and discerning man, perfect in philosophic investigation"; see Lawee, *Isaac Abarbanel's Stance toward Tradition*, 45. It is believed that del Medigo lectured in philosophy at Padua, thus being "the first Jew to have been an instructor in philosophy at a European university" (Feldman, *Philosophy in a Time of Crisis*, 164). Del Medigo—addressed by Seymour Feldman (*ibid.*) as Pico's "tutor"—met Pico in 1485 and discussed with him matters of Averroist and Aristotelian philosophy. In the introduction to his commentary on Averroës' *De substantia orbis* he praised Pico as "*homo valde intelligens, philosophus honorabilis, diligens viritatem, cui similem vere non vidi in hac aetate*" (*Expositio averrois de substantia orbis*, Biblioteca Apostolica Vaticana Ms Codex Vat. Lat. 4553, f. 1v, quoted from Hames, "Elijah Delmedigo," 50; see *ibid.*, 39). Cf. also Kieszkowski, "Les rapports entre Elie del Medigo et Pic de la Mirandole"; Bland, "Elijah del Medigo's Averroist Response."

close contact with the Abarbanel family. Another link, of course, was Abarbanel's eldest son Judah, who was to become famous as Leone Ebreo. His *Dialoghi d'amore* (written around 1502) rank among the most important Platonic treatises of the Renaissance; they also witness Hermetic and kabbalistic readings of esoteric tradition in a Jewish key.⁴⁷

Like Pico della Mirandola, Alemanno and Abarbanel sought to overcome the rivalry between philosophy and kabbalah, albeit not—as Pico did—by claiming the universal Christian truth to be found in kabbalah, but by insisting on the superiority of Jewish tradition. Even this kind of modest synthesis, however, raised suspicion among fellow kabbalists. Isaac da Pisa, Isaac Mar Hayyim, Judah Hayyat, Elijah Hayyim of Genazzano, and others criticized this approach and “sought to demonstrate rational philosophy's limitations and its ultimate inability to penetrate the superior insights of theurgic Kabbalah.”⁴⁸

Taken together, these conflicts clearly reveal the problematic implications of conflicting narratives of ‘tradition’ for religious identities in a pluralistic situation. With their rejection of multilinear models of *prisca theologia*, Jewish kabbalists were protesting against what they felt to be a deliberate misreading of their tradition by (proselytizing) Christian authors. In so doing, they followed the example of the rabbinic critique of Christian ‘misreading.’⁴⁹ It was not until the late sixteenth and early seventeenth centuries that Jewish authors attributed at least some authority to non-Jewish *prisci theologi* and adopted elements of a multilinear historiography. Examples are Gedalyah ibn Yehiya, Abraham Yagel, Asaria de' Rossi, or Menasseh ben Israel.⁵⁰ This slight shift might be attributed to an increasing influence of Pico's

⁴⁷ Although we should not forget that—as in the messianic writings of his father—Leone Ebreo was reluctant to substantiate his argumentation explicitly with kabbalistic doctrines (see Idel, *Messianic Mystics*, 138–140), a close reading of the *Dialoghi d'amore* reveals formulations and ideas that are best explicable against a kabbalistic background. In one passage, Leone Ebreo even associates Platonism with the kabbalah (*Philosophy of Love*, 296). A balanced interpretation is provided by Feldman, *Philosophy in a Time of Crisis*, 166–175.

⁴⁸ Lawee, *Isaac Abarbanel's Stance toward Tradition*, 46.

⁴⁹ See Idel, “Jewish Thinkers versus Christian Kabbalah,” 49.

⁵⁰ See the examples presented in Idel, “*Prisca Theologia* in Marsilio Ficino and in Some Jewish Treatments,” 155–156.